Climate Crisis Response Committee Annual Report 2025-2026 Academic Year

Climate Crisis Response Committee Members

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Introduction

Since the passage of the Climate Crisis Response, Climate Justice and Sustainable Practices Policy (CCRP) by the Portland Public Schools (PPS) Board in March of 2022, the district has taken action to meet ambitious goals that will impact the health and safety of students and communities throughout Portland. The CCRP mandated the establishment of a Climate Crisis Response Committee (CCRC) to “monitor effective implementation, transparency, and tracking of progress” of the CCRP. This Annual Report of the CCRC celebrates this year's accomplishments, sheds light on challenges to overcome, and provides recommendations to maintain PPS on its trailblazing path as a climate leader.

Background

The committee is composed of nine community members, including two high school student representatives. It convened six times prior to submission of this report: an orientation to welcome the committee's five new members, three quarterly meetings, and two special topics sessions to discuss recommendations for the district's developing artificial intelligence (AI) guidance and the upcoming review of the CCRP by the PPS School Board Policy Committee. The CCRC's work on the latter two topics is on-going and the recommendations will be shared with the Board as soon as they are available.

Key Successes

Emissions Reductions

Staff efforts to integrate the CCRP into "the way PPS does work" are underlined by the upcoming high school modernization projects that have maintained the commitment to full electrification. With these choices, PPS is projected to reach the CCRP's ambitious 2030 goal of reducing greenhouse gas emissions by 50% from the 2019 baseline. The school board's steadfast commitment to electrification, in light of limited resources, is applauded and serves as a critical inflection point on PPS's path toward becoming a decarbonized school district.

The recent final approval of the PCEF Collaborating with Climate Action grant represented another significant win to further reduce emissions within PPS. This grant awards the district $25.6 million for infrastructure projects, including energy efficiency, upgrading HVAC systems, and green schoolyards. These resources are critical for achieving facility upgrades that will not only impact decarbonization goals but also the safety, health, and wellness of the most vulnerable front-line students and communities.

Engagement, Resilience, and Wellness

Now in its second year, the Climate Friendly Public Schools Program, funded by the Portland Clean Energy Fund (PCEF), has enabled student-led climate projects to provide a broader range of climate action, empowerment, and engagement to our middle and high school students. Through the strategic effort and creative partnership building of the Climate Justice & Sustainability team, 100% of eligible schools are participating. The program engaged over 2,700 students in climate project development and implementation,

and student groups anticipate engaging nearly 20,000 more students through their project activities.

Additionally, the annual Climate Awareness Student Survey was disseminated again this April to all high school students in PPS. This survey, created by the CCRC student representatives, collects information regarding students' perceptions and awareness of PPS's climate response, as well as avenues for engagement. Annual distribution of the survey provides a mechanism for capturing changes in these responses over time, affording the district vital feedback to best align their efforts with student input.

Notable Challenges

PPS also took some notable steps backward. Last year, the Climate Justice & Sustainability team debuted the Climate Policy Public Dashboard, an interactive tool showing PPS's progress in systematically adopting the necessary projects, policies, and plans for meeting the objectives of the CCRP. Due to budget constraints, the district's contract with Envisio, the company that hosted the dashboard, was not renewed and the dashboard was lost, resulting in reduced transparency on PPS's progress and accountability toward its climate goals.

Further, the five-person Climate Justice & Sustainability team has experienced significant capacity limitations this year. Due to budget cuts, the Climate Resiliency Program manager position was eliminated last year, and two positions - the Energy & Sustainability Program Manager and Sustainability Project Manager - have been vacant for an extended period. In addition to notably reducing the team's capacity, the Energy & Sustainability Program Manager vacancy has resulted in a lack of utilization of the **Decarbonizations Roadmap tool** - a tool that the district invested in just last year. This tool allows the district to track its climate progress, make updates as variables change, and to test how different scenarios will impact emissions reductions, equity, cost, and student health. Without this position, the Climate Advisor was unable to share detailed decarbonization and implementation progress with the CCRC, hampering the committee's ability to perform its duties. Fortunately, this position has recently been filled and the new Energy & Sustainability Program Manager is set to start in May 2026.

Lastly, and most concerning to the committee, the Climate Advisor position was recently eliminated due to budget cuts, terminating at the end of June 2026. The Climate Advisor has overseen the implementation of the CCRP over the past four years, taking a systems approach to integrating the policy into the district's many departments. As other Climate

Justice & Sustainability team positions have been eliminated or vacated, the Climate Advisor has maintained the momentum of CCRP integration and transparency with the community, including serving as liaison to the CCRC. This loss of institutional knowledge and relationship building across departments for climate action could greatly limit progress towards the CCRP's goals without careful attention.

2025-26 Recommendations

Embed Transparency and Engagement Tools

The planned re-creation of the **Climate Policy Public Dashboard** on PPS's website should be prioritized to restore transparency into the district's progress toward its climate goals. Falling under the responsibilities of the now eliminated Climate Advisor, the committee strongly recommends directing resources to its completion and maintenance. A system should be put in place across the many PPS departments to track and report the data for the dashboard on a regular basis. Once live, a communications strategy for sharing it with students, staff, and the broader community should be undertaken. The committee believes executing this is a priority.

The **Climate Awareness Student Survey**, created by students for students, is a powerful tool for understanding how high schoolers feel about PPS's actions to address climate change and how best to engage students in this work. However, the impact of the survey, including specifically how the feedback has influenced PPS's climate efforts, is unclear. The committee recommends establishing a mechanism for PPS staff to publicly share, respond to, and incorporate learnings from Climate Awareness Student Survey responses.

Ensure Ownership and Capacity of CCRP Implementation

With the elimination of the Climate Advisor position, ownership of the CCRP's implementation must be strategically and explicitly incorporated into remaining staff member's responsibilities throughout the district. The foundational work to integrate and operationalize the policy's goals across departments has been laid and the committee encourages leadership to ensure capacity and accountability. Realistically, a reduced Climate Justice & Sustainability team will have significantly less capacity and progress will be negatively impacted. Creative strategies for engaging volunteers or new funding partners to cushion the impact are highly recommended.

Improve CCRC's Capacity and Effectiveness

In alignment with the CCRC's stated duties "to receive regular reports and data from District staff on the current status and planned implementation of the Policy goals and directives, including the impact of the policy implementation on frontline communities," the staff update shared during quarterly CCRC meetings should be standardized to the CCRP's goals and include metrics whenever possible. Recreation of the CCRP Dashboard, as well as district utilization of the Decarbonization Roadmap tool, should facilitate this recommendation. Additionally, the committee recommends adjusting the timing for recruitment and onboarding of new CCRC members to begin earlier, affording the committee more time during the school year to perform its duties.

Closing

This year, PPS has notably maintained its momentum toward a decarbonized school district and ramped up student engagement in climate activities. Additional action toward the CCRP goals is taking place across the district; however, without the tools or staff capacity to track, report, and share them, it is difficult to assess progress. Looking ahead, addressing reduced capacity on the Climate Justice & Sustainability and restoring transparency with the PPS community should be prioritized. In light of our current climate crisis, the district's efforts and commitment to climate justice and sustainability has served as a model for communities throughout the country. Maintaining our momentum in our current funding shortage will take a concerted effort by district leaders, but it is of the highest priority.